

Explain your plight to the owner and he'll find *something* for a night, even if it's an unused maid's room in back. In most countries we've visited, I've sensed that this technique would work. But, as I said, we've never had to try it.

A growing racket in the hotel business is the so-called guaranteed reservation. Give the hotel your credit card number and you get a "guaranteed" room. The hotel charges you for the room whether you show up or not. But a friend was recently on a delayed flight to New York. He got to his hotel at 4:00 A.M. to claim his guaranteed room. The desk clerk apologized and said that no rooms were available. It seems some guarantees are more guaranteed than others. Since my friend showed up to claim his guaranteed-room-that-wasn't, he didn't have to pay for it. If he had *failed* to show up to claim his guaranteed-room-that-wasn't, he would have been charged \$250 on his American Express card.

Avoid being ripped off by unscrupulous innkeepers. Travel without reservations and stay in hotels that keep their rooms for walk-in customers.

AIRFARE: TAKE A TRAVEL AGENT TO LUNCH

For retired travelers, deregulation of the airline industry was like manna from heaven. Most airlines now give deep discounts to travelers who can live with "restrictions." Buy your ticket thirty days in advance, stay over a Saturday night, and fly midweek, and you can save 50 percent or more. Those conditions may restrict some people. But retired travelers almost always plan in advance, stay for more than a week, and choose to travel midweek, when airports are less crowded.

Ask whether your travel agent offers big discounts. If he doesn't, choose one of the "bucket shop" operators that advertise in *The Village Voice* or publications that cater to students. "Bucket shops" do high volumes and receive special discounts from the airlines; they pass those discounts